

DON'T SAY CHEESE

Sixty-seven per cent of Indians have never visited a dentist, reports a just-released national survey

DOWN IN THE MOUTH

Oral hygiene is possibly the least-understood activity; only half of the respondents seem to be following the basic rules of toothcare.



51% use toothpaste and brush; the rest don't bother

28% brush teeth twice a day; the rest don't

19% feel it's essential to brush at night; the rest don't

With the Government promoting 'Oral Health for All by 2020' and the Indian Dental Association—the apex body of Indian dental professionals—planning the World Dental Show 2009 from October 9 to 11 in Mumbai, the nation's dental future might just get that much-needed sparkle.

BAD MOUTH

The state of national oral health is poor across age groups, but the survey shows how tooth decay reaches dangerous levels by the time one reaches mid-life. A comparative study of oral health between adolescents and adults reveals the rapid rate of deterioration:

■ If tooth decay is prevalent among 63% of 15-year-olds across the country,

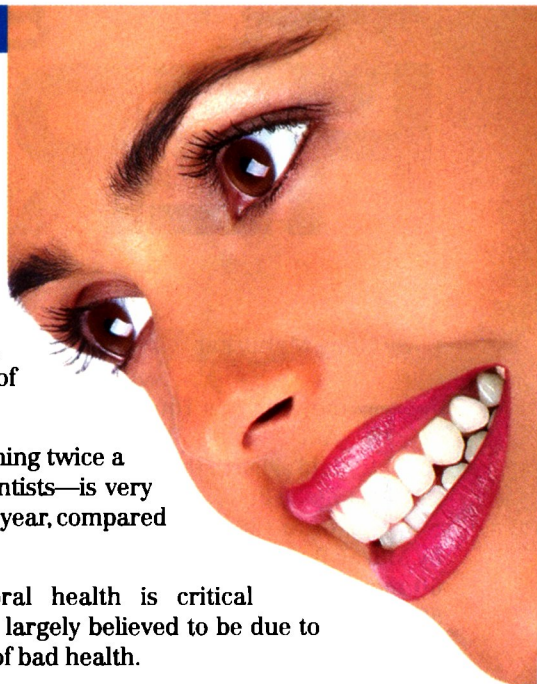
TOOTHY TALE

The national Consumer Usage and Attitudes Survey, conducted on 11,324 people across the country by the Indian Market Research Bureau and sponsored by Colgate-Palmolive (India) Limited shows abysmal awareness and habits on oral health:

■ Most Indians seek professional help only if there's a problem. One-fifth suffer from tooth sensitivity, yet half of them don't do anything about it.

■ Awareness of preventive care—brushing twice a day or routine twice a year visit to dentists—is very low. Only 3 per cent visit a dentist once a year, compared to 57 per cent globally.

■ Most people don't know that oral health is critical to overall health. Dental problems are largely believed to be due to improper eating habits and not a sign of bad health.



ZIP YOUR LIPS TO DENTISTS



70% suffer from cavities, but only 58% bother to visit dentists

53% get mouth odour, but only 11% take it seriously

64% have bleeding gums, but only 28% take recourse to medicine

63% get mouth ulcers, but only 21% consult a doctor



it reaches 80% among adults between age 35 and 44.

■ If gum diseases are prevalent among 68% of teens, it goes up to as much as 90% among the middle-aged.

■ If the mean DMFT (decayed, missing, filled teeth) score among 15-year-olds is 2.4, it is as high as 5.4 among the 35-44 age group.

■ compiled by **Damayanti Datta**